

Momentous achievement: This was Antim's second successive Worlds bronze, joining Vinesh as the most decorated Indian female wrestlers at the Worlds. GETTY IMAGES

and was a witness to a similar embarrassment (Vinesh's issue) at the Paris Olympics. It seems he has not learnt anything from that episode," said Sanjay.

"Both the wrestler and the support staff, who were assisting him, were responsible for this. Strict action will be taken against both. They have wasted a lot of Government money, which was spent on the (15-day) preparatory camp abroad."

This was the third such instance in about a year. Promising wrestler Neha Sangwan (59kg) was ineligible to compete at the World Under-20 Championships in August and was banned for two years by the WFI for negligence in managing her weight.

The recurrence of such episodes has prompted the WFI to consider a policy to tackle such issues. **Starting with the trials for the World under-23 championships in Serbia, the federation has done away with the two-kg relaxation given to the wrestlers during selection trials in order to make them strictly follow weight restrictions.**

Other Indian freestyle wrestlers also failed to make an impact. Twenty-year-old Mukul Dahiya (86kg) came closest to a medal but lost 0-10 to two-time World champion Iranian Kamran Ghasempur in the bronze medal bout.

Trying to re-establish himself in 92kg, Deepak Punia, a former Worlds silver medallist in 86kg, won one bout but lost the next. Vicky (97kg) also put up some good performances before facing reversal in the repechage.

The promising Sujeet Kalkal (65kg), a Hungary Ranking Series gold medallist, fought well but narrowly lost 5-6 to Olympic silver medallist and eventual champion Rahman Amouzadkhalili of Iran in the quarterfinals. He eventually bowed out in the repechage.

Antim saved India the blushes. The young wrestler — who underperformed at the Paris Olympics and was deported on disciplinary

grounds after her sister used her accreditation card to enter the Olympic Village — recovered from that ignominious episode to refocus on her game and land a bronze. This was her second successive Worlds bronze (considering that the 2024 World Championships only had competitions in non-Olympic weights). With it, she joined Vinesh as the most decorated Indian female wrestlers at the Worlds.

The fourth-seeded 21-year-old steamrolled Spain's World junior silver medallist Carla Jaume Soler 10-0 in the pre-quarterfinals and beat China's 55kg Worlds silver medallist Zhang Jin 9-8 in the quarterfinals, before going down 3-5 to World No.1 and Paris Olympics silver medallist Lucia Yepez Guzman.

Antim then beat another Paris Olympian, Emma Jonna Malmgren, 9-1 in the bronze medal match and etched her name among the all-time great Indian women wrestlers. Her tears reflected her regret at a missed opportunity in Paris — a lesson that should make her wiser.

Meanwhile, Asian champion Manisha Bhanwala (62kg), who entered the repechage, could not rise to the occasion. For the women's team, mostly comprising youngsters — World Under-20 champion Tapsya Gahlawat (57kg) and Priya Malik (another World Under-20 medallist who lost to Olympic medallist Cuban Milaimy Marin Potrille in a 76kg bronze medal match) — the Zagreb exposure was valuable ahead of important assignments, including the 2026 Asian Games and 2028 Olympics.

There was little hope from the Indian Greco-Roman wrestlers. Asian bronze medallist Nitesh (97kg) and Aman (77kg) had outside chances as they reached the repechage rounds. Nineteen-year-old Worlds Under-20 bronze medallist Suraj (60kg) upset former World champion and Olympian Victor Ciobanu of Moldova 3-1 to underline his talent.

With the uncertainty and chaos surrounding wrestling administration finally ending earlier this year, the WFI and the wrestlers should learn their lessons from the below-par Zagreb outing and prepare to deliver an improved performance at the Asian Games in a year's time.



Antim beat Spain's World junior silver medallist Carla Jaume Soler, China's Worlds silver medallist Zhang Jin, and Paris Olympian Emma Jonna Malmgren on her way to the bronze